Reble With A Cause

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

With her recent work on major film soundtracks like *Dhurandhar*, Reble has crossed over from Meghalaya's independent hip-hop scene to national popular culture

There is a version of Daiaphi Lamare who, as a child in Nangbah, West Jaiñtia Hills, ate her lunch alone and barely spoke. There is another who now commands stages across the country as Reble, one of Northeast India's most distinctive voices in hip-hop. The 24-year-old rapper-singer, whose given name, Daiaphi, means 'I'll take care of you', grew up in Nangbah and did a BTech in Civil Engineering. Daiaphi insists her two names are not incompatible. "Reble is a part of Daia," she says, "expressing emotions of rebellion, anger, so-called negative emotions according to society."

Music, she says, is what changed her: "When I discovered music, I discovered confidence." The harmony of her introverted and extroverted nature, capable of working a room and withdrawing into the glittering sights of her mind after the noise settles, shapes everything she writes: dense, image-heavy lyrics that reward close listening without spelling things out. "I write like I'm writing a poem," she says. "You get it, or you don't."

HER TAKE

"People who make it don't work like people who don't make it. They're not normal anymore. They become so obsessed with what they do that it borders on illness. That obsession is what makes the art good"

The instinct to make art entirely on her own terms has shaped her career. She never expected music to become more than a passion project. Years of independent releases built a reputation that led to Bollywood through *Dhurandhar* and performances at major festivals, including Rolling Loud India. She refuses to rank milestones, calling them "tiny little steps" towards a much larger body of work she hopes to build over decades. Her latest single, 'Praying Mantis', turns on the pun between prey and pray, an indictment of people who "use a moral or religious high ground to have power". Next comes an EP and a string of collaborations, including with fellow Northeastern artistes.

"I just want to make good music. I don't want to alter my art to make [the outcome] favour me," she says. On the scarcity of women in hip-hop, she's candid, calling for a stronger ecosystem that encourages more women to enter the genre, even as she resists defining her own journey through gender alone. ■

–Aparmita Das

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**